

EXERCISE TECHNIQUE, DESCRIPTIONS, AND TIPS

RECOMMENDED EQUIPMENT

These exercise progressions are as “low-tech” as possible, since not everyone has access to top-shelf facilities or equipment. The only equipment you need to get started is a set of rings.

Some of the techniques shown use a set of parallel bars, mini-parallel bars called parallettes, or a singular bar like a high bar. Most of the bar movements can be substituted on the rings and most of the parallel bar movements can be substituted on the parallettes.

The type of rings or equipment you use will not make much difference. Some of the different brands available include Rogue rings and EXF rings. Wood rings are preferable over plastic rings because the feel is better, and it holds chalk better. Rogue also sells high-quality parallettes. Check out different gymnastics suppliers, or you can follow a do-it-yourself guide to make your own equipment at home. Here are two examples of websites that provide do-it-yourself instructions for rings and parallettes:

- Rings: www.instructables.com/id/How-to-make-PVC-gymnastic-fitness-rings
- Parallettes: www.celtickane.com/projects/homemade-parallettes

Rings maybe be mounted outside from a tree or inside in various places like on a pull-up bar in a doorway. Some people have installed rings from their ceilings by hanging them from cross beams. Parallettes, on the other hand, can be used anywhere. A wall may be helpful for some of the progressions.

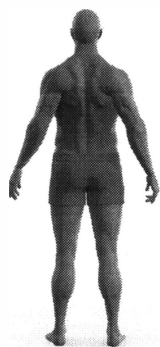
If you do not have access to equipment, you can still get started by being creative. For example, you can make a pull-up bar by hanging a broomstick from a tree with rope. Whatever you choose, remember to make safety your top priority. That being said, here are some alternatives for performing pull-ups and rows without traditional equipment:

- Pull-ups: trees, stairwells, playgrounds, ledges, sturdy door frames, or anything else you can hang from.
- Rows: Hang underneath a table or chair, put a broom across counters, tables, or chairs and hang underneath it, hang something like rings from your pull-up bar, or lower your rings.

BASIC POSITIONING, IMPORTANT EXERCISES, AND COMMON FAULTS

Many of these basic positions are found in the sample warm-up routine. The warm-up is a good place for you to perform them, as they will help you develop body awareness and connective tissue integrity, which will help you stay injury-free.

Scapular Positioning



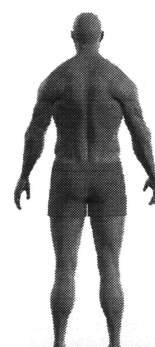
Retracted



Protracted



Elevated



Depressed

The above images show important differences in scapular positioning. All bodyweight exercises require proper scapular positioning in order to be performed effectively—and, in some cases, safely. *Retracted* and *protracted* mean *squeezed back* and *moved forward*, respectively. Likewise, *elevated* and *depressed* mean *up* and *down*, respectively.

Hollow, Arch, Plank, Reverse Plank



These are basic body positioning drills that will get you accustomed the different shapes needed for correct execution of bodyweight skills. You will eventually use each of these for advanced movements like handstands and other exercises. If you drill proper positioning in your warm-ups early on, it will set you up for long-term success.

When you perform positioning drills, focus on maintaining correct alignment (hollow, straight, or arched). You may need to see yourself in order to make corrections. Use a mirror or a camera. You could also ask a coach or athlete more experienced than you to watch you perform these drills and tell you what you need to work on. Eventually, you should be able to perform these drills with your eyes closed and maintain correct alignment.

Side planks, while they are not shown, essentially involve the side of your body facing the ground while your body itself is straight.

Rings Support and Rings-Turned-Out (RTO) Support Holds

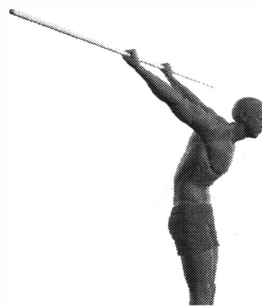


Rings support and *rings-turned-out (RTO) support* holds are critical for developing rings-specific strength movements. They are included in the warm-up because they also help you develop the connective tissue strength needed for many of the straight-arm isometric exercises. Focus on these if you have any rings aspirations or want to progress toward one-arm chin-ups.

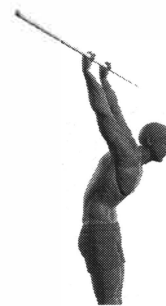
German Hang



Rings



Supinated Grip



Pronated Grip

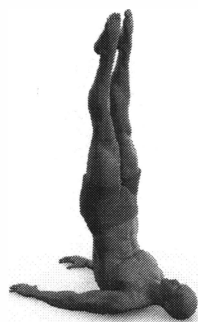
The *German hang* is discussed thoroughly in the *back lever progression* section. This static position and the process of moving in and out of it (often called *skin the cat*) is critical for developing shoulder flexibility as well as connective tissue strength in your shoulders and elbows. German hangs are as important as rings support and ring-turned-out support holds, to any athlete with rings or upper-level unilateral strength aspirations.

False Grip



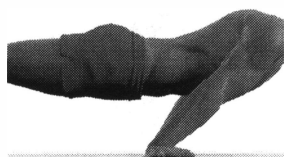
The *false grip* is discussed more thoroughly in the muscle-up section: it is one of the most important movements when you are learning to perform muscle-ups on both the rings and the bar, so begin practicing it now.

Candlestick

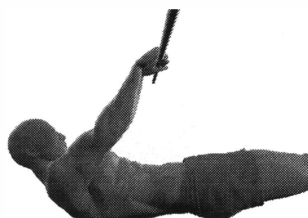


The *candlestick* positions are alternatives to the headstand and handstand positions. If you are a beginner and do not feel ready to move into headstands or handstands, put this movement into your warm-up, as it will help you get accustomed to the feeling of having your body inverted and vertically oriented. Focus on maintaining straight body positioning; do not allow your body to sag.

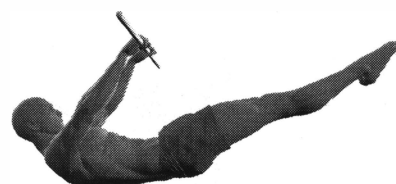
Common Bodyweight Faults



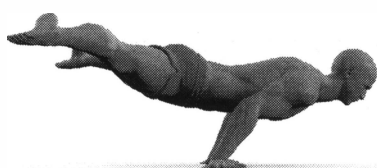
Body Arched or Sagging



Chest Rounded



Too Hollowed / Back Rounded



Arms Bent, Body Arched



Chest Too Rounded



Banana Handstand,
as Opposed to a Straight Handstand

These are some of the common faults when performing bodyweight strength exercises. These faults signify improper body positioning during a movement or while executing an isometric hold, and are actually strength deficits that need to be worked out. (The “fault” makes the movement easier to perform, though incorrectly.) If you discover a fault in your own position, the best course is to downgrade your current progression and work your way back up with proper body positioning.

COMMON ABBREVIATIONS

These are common bodyweight strength training abbreviations that are used on the charts, throughout this book, and when discussing bodyweight strength training in any community.

Common Terms

BW Bodyweight

Equipment

R Rings

PB Parallel Bars

FL Front Lever (also means Floor when paired with PB)

Body and Hand Positioning

BA Bent-Arm

BB Bent-Body

SA Straight-Arm

SB Straight-Body

Adv Advanced

Str Straddle

Deg Number of Degrees for Body or Hand Positioning
(see also: RTO)

RTO Rings-Turned-Out

FG False Grip

Exercises

HS Handstand

HeSPU Headstand Pushup

HSPU Handstand Pushup

BL Back Lever

Inv Inverted Hang

OAC One-Arm Chin-up

PL Planche

PU Pushup

PPPU Pseudo Planche Pushup

GH German Hang

RC Rope Climb

OA One-Arm

EL Elbow Lever

Ecc Eccentrics

BTB Behind the Back

Clap Clapping your Hands Together

Slap Slapping your Hands on a Body Part

BWD Backward

FWD Forward